

KIT 6 OF 20 · 45–60 MINUTES · WHOLE STAFF · RUN KITS 1 AND 2 FIRST

AI for Communication: Parent Messages and Tone

Everything you need before you present. Read this once (about 8 minutes), run the 15-minute prep checklist, and you're ready.

What this session is

The session takes AI to the most visible surface of teaching: what goes home. Staff learn what AI genuinely does well in family communication (drafts, tone repair, reading level, reformatting) and the one thing it threatens (their voice), work through three makeovers on Ms. Rivera's screen (the newsletter, the difficult email, the positive-note batch), and practice the tone-repair kit on the messages that actually go wrong. The 18-minute lab produces one deliverable, done completely: **next week's actual family message, taken from blank page to scheduled send: drafted, voiced, the hard sentence repaired, action items on top.** The positive-note batch launches from the First 48 Hours sheet.

THE STANCE: REPEAT IT UNTIL IT'S FURNITURE

AI drafts the message; the teacher makes it theirs. Families hear the teacher, not the tool. And hard news is never delivered by a draft: you call.

Why the stakes are worth it: in a field experiment set in a summer program for students retaking a course they had failed, one individualized sentence home per week cut the failure rate by 41% (Kraft & Rogers, 2015); and communication drafting is among the most common uses behind the ~5.9 hours/week that weekly AI users save (Gallup, 2025). The barrier was never caring; it was hours. That's the cost this session changes.

Who should present it

Same bar as Kits 1–5: any confident colleague. You don't need to be a communications expert; the makeovers are fully scripted and the tone repairs are written to be read aloud. What you must hold firmly are the two lines that never move: the translation red line on slide 15 (no public AI translation of family messages; you cannot review what you cannot read) and the human-only list on slide 16: safety, discipline, grief, and special-education news travel by voice, never by draft. If the room pushes for efficiency there, the answer is warm and immovable.

One prep item matters most: the pre-session email. The lab drafts a real message, so staff must arrive knowing what they owe families this week (newsletter, unit update, event reminder). Second item: add an empty "Communication" heading to the staff prompt doc from Kit 2. Third: have your own awkward sentence ready (the fee reminder, the permission-slip nag); a facilitator example makes lab step 3 land faster.

The session at a glance

Segment	Minutes	What happens
Welcome & why messages matter	0:00–0:05	The margin problem; Kraft & Rogers' one-sentence finding
The tool and the voice	0:05–0:12	What AI does well here; the beige risk; the two permanent rules
Three makeovers	0:12–0:24	Newsletter (Ms. Rivera's screen), difficult email, positive-note batch; diagnose practice
Tone, and the lines that hold	0:24–0:31	The tone-repair kit; call-the-repair practice; the translation red line; the human-only list
Lab: one real message	0:31–0:53	Draft → voice pass → the hard sentence → access pass & sign-off → share-out
Making it stick	0:53–0:56	Inventory; honest limits; three commitments; the month ahead
First 48 hours & close	0:56–0:58	Action sheet + exit ticket

Core session is 58 minutes. For a 45-minute slot: two diagnosis calls on slide 12, one worked repair on slide 14, lab step 1 gets five minutes and step 4 folds into step 2's read-aloud, two share-out voices; the script marks the cuts.

Your 15-minute prep checklist

- ☐ **Send the staff email** (2 min, two days ahead): "Bring a charged device and the next real message you owe families (newsletter, update, reminder). You'll leave with it written."
- ☐ **Pick your own awkward sentence** (3 min): the fee reminder or permission-slip nag you'd write this week; you'll want a personal example when lab step 3 lands.
- ☐ **Add a "Communication" section** to the staff prompt doc (1 min).
- ☐ **Skim the script once** (6 min): the makeovers on slides 9–11 and the lab's evolving newsletter on slides 19–27 are the heart; read those aloud once.
- ☐ **Click through the deck** (2 min): confirm all 35 slides display and the Ms. Rivera tracker chip shows top-right.
- ☐ **Print the handouts** (1 min): Participant Handout, First 48 Hours, Exit Ticket, one of each per person.

Room, tech & timing

Same setup as Kits 1–5: projector, Wi-Fi, pair seating, a visible clock. Timing discipline: the lab must start by 0:31. Cut discussion before you ever cut the lab; the two things you never cut are slide 15 (the translation red line) and slide 16 (the human-only list). Expect one strong current in the room: somebody has sent an email they regret. The 24-hour rule lands with real feeling; give it a beat.

Facilitator FAQ

"Can I just paste a parent's email into the tool to draft a reply?"

Strip it first. A parent's email contains names and identifying details, and Kit 1's rule covers families too: describe the situation ("a parent frustrated about a grade"), never paste the identity. The reply comes back generic; you personalize it in your own inbox.

"What about families who read limited English?"

Write the original in plain language: short sentences, no idioms, action items first; that's the version every family can use, and the version district translators work best from. Official documents travel your district's translation channels; that's their obligation. Teachers never run a family message through a public AI translator: you cannot review what you cannot read, and slide 15 says so plainly.

"Doesn't a weekly note batch feel automated?"

The batch drafts *starters*; the teacher matches each to a real kid and rewrites it personally. Kraft & Rogers tested weekly individualized messages, so the personalizing step is part of what was actually tested; a generic batch is not the thing that produced the result. Say that to the room, and say it that carefully: the study bundled individualized content, weekly frequency, and improvement framing, so no one ingredient is proven to be the active one.

"What about our messaging platform's built-in AI?"

District-adopted platforms follow district policy and their own agreements; today is about public general-purpose tools and the habits that transfer. Park platform questions for leadership; don't endorse or criticize a product by name.

After the session: 5 minutes

- Collect exit tickets; they double as PD documentation.
- Skim the "communication situation I still want help with" answers; recurring ones set follow-up #2's agenda.
- Note who left without a scheduled message; a kind nudge this week beats a cold check-in at the PLC.

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